



The Square We Keep

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Today we honor a place so ordinary that most of us walk across it without looking down. The public square. The plaza, the town green, the common ground at the center of a city, where a person can stand without buying anything and still belong.

2 Consider how long we have kept it. In Athens the agora held the assembly and the debate and the market and the daily business of being a citizen from at least the sixth century before the common era; in Rome the Forum gathered the law, the worship, and the argument of the republic into one open ground; in the towns of medieval Europe the central square took in the market, the governance, the ceremony, and the crowd. [Parallelism] Different centuries, the same instinct. People built an empty middle on purpose and called it the most important room in the city, though it had no roof.

3 The square asked nothing of you. It did not check your purse at the edge. [Antithesis] A citizen of an old town could enter the plaza with empty hands and full standing, because the right to be there came with belonging and not with buying. This is the quiet thing the square was built to do, and it is the thing we are losing. It is to meet the stranger you would otherwise never meet; it is to stand beside the person whose politics you do not share; it is to be counted among people you did not choose. [Anaphora]

4 There is a detail at the Athenian agora that I keep returning to. The site still holds the remains of the Stoa, the covered walkways that let citizens gather and argue when the weather turned. Someone, long ago, looked at the rain and decided the conversation should not have to stop. It is a small thing. It tells you what they thought the talking was worth.

5 We have been leaving. The corporate plaza now stands where the common ground used to, the privately owned public space that looks open and is not, that admits the customer and moves the rest of us along. The screen took the rest. Since the early years of this century the meeting, the argument, the slow work of showing up has migrated from the square to the feed, and the room at the center of the city has begun to empty. [Personification] Attendance at the town meeting has fallen since the 1970s. The revolutions were declared in squares; the Bastille fell in a public street, and the colonists who would not be ruled gathered, of all the unremarkable places, in the town square. [Allusion] We are not gathering there now.

6 So the square waits. It is older than any of us and patient in a way we are not, holding its open middle for whoever comes back to stand in it. The Romans had a phrase for the thing that belongs to everyone and to no one, the res publica, the public thing, and they meant a ground you could not sell because it was already ours. It is still there, most of it, under the new towers and the rented benches. The door is open. We have simply stopped walking through it.

Devices, and why they are here:

Parallelism (paragraph 2): “In Athens the agora held the assembly and the debate and the market and the daily business of being a citizen from at least the sixth century before the common era; in Rome the Forum gathered the law, the worship, and the argument of the republic into one open ground; in the towns of medieval Europe the central square took in the market, the governance, the ceremony, and the crowd.”

Three matched clauses (agora, Forum, medieval square) carry the historical accumulation under one repeated grammatical shape, building the case by cumulative weight rather than a single claim, which is the register's engine of cadence. The repeated mid-clause structure is parallelism, not anaphora, since the echo is structural and not a fixed opening word.

Antithesis (paragraph 3): “The square asked nothing of you. It did not check your purse at the edge.” The balanced opposition between belonging and buying (full standing with empty hands) sets the square's open access against the purchase-gated private space, sharpening the value-claim through contrast in the small-versus-large manner the Tribute favors.

Anaphora (paragraph 3): “It is to meet the stranger you would otherwise never meet; it is to stand beside the person whose politics you do not share; it is to be counted among people you did not choose.”

The repeated 'it is to' frame opens successive clauses to accumulate the civic meaning of the square (meeting the stranger, standing beside the opponent, being counted), letting weight build by escalation; placed at the start of each clause, it is anaphora rather than mid-clause parallelism.

Personification (paragraph 5): “The screen took the rest. Since the early years of this century the meeting, the argument, the slow work of showing up has migrated from the square to the feed, and the room at the center of the city has begun to empty.”

Treating the screen as an actor that 'took the rest' compresses the diffuse shift to digital life into a single quiet agent, carrying the loss through a concrete grammatical subject instead of an abstract statement that something declined.

Allusion (paragraph 5): “The revolutions were declared in squares; the Bastille fell in a public street, and the colonists who would not be ruled gathered, of all the unremarkable places, in the town square.” The fall of the Bastille is a widely recognized reference that lends the square its revolutionary weight in a single stroke, borrowing the reader's existing knowledge so the claim that democracy was made in public space lands without lengthy proof.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's position on the public square across the opener?
 - A) A nostalgic ideal that never truly granted the open access the writer attributes to it
 - B) A place of enduring civic worth that the public has gradually abandoned rather than lost to any single cause
 - C) A historical institution whose usefulness ended once digital platforms offered a more efficient substitute
 - D) A contested site whose value depends on which political faction controls it at a given moment

2. In the fourth paragraph, the writer dwells on the covered walkways of the Stoa primarily to
- A) honor the care earlier citizens gave to keeping public conversation alive
 - B) prove that the agora was the largest public space of its era
 - C) establish the architectural sophistication of ancient Greek engineering
 - D) argue that modern squares should be redesigned for shelter

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The opener consecrates the square as a durable shared good (the agora, Forum, and medieval plaza show continuity) and frames the present as a retreat the public has chosen ("We have simply stopped walking through it"), so the best reading pairs lasting worth with gradual abandonment. The option naming digital platforms as a superior replacement inverts the writer's stance, which mourns the migration to the feed rather than endorsing it. The faction-control option imports a partisan frame the consecratory passage never raises. The option calling the open access a myth contradicts the text's claim that the square admitted citizens "with empty hands and full standing," reading the piece against its own assertion.

2. Answer A. The paragraph turns the small architectural fact into a statement of value ("It tells you what they thought the talking was worth"), so the walkways primarily honor the ancients' care for sustained public talk. The engineering-sophistication option names a true subject of the detail but assigns a purpose the consecratory passage does not serve, admiring craft rather than care. The redesign option imports a call to action the Tribute register never issues. The largest-space option asserts a comparison the opener never makes, a fact outside the passage.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer chooses to consecrate the square rather than argue for it, never naming an opponent or rebutting a counterclaim. How does that consecratory stance shape what the piece can and cannot persuade a reader to do?
2. The opener ends on 'We have simply stopped walking through it' rather than on a call to act. What is gained, and what is risked, by closing a piece about civic decline without telling the reader what to do?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The piece treats the square's worth as already settled and spends its energy elevating that worth rather than proving it, which lets it move quickly through three civilizations under one parallel frame without stopping to defend each claim. The cost is that a skeptical reader who does not already grant the square's value is never argued into it; the strength is that a reader who shares the esteem feels it deepened. By refusing an opponent, the writer keeps the tone reverent and inclusive, the joined 'we' that the Tribute register depends on, so the loss reads as a shared shortcoming rather than someone else's fault.

2. Closing on 'We have simply stopped walking through it' hands the reader a fact rather than an instruction, which suits a register that consecrates rather than commands. The gain is dignity and restraint: the line places the responsibility quietly with the reader without hectoring, and it leaves a thread hanging instead of tying a neat bow. The risk is that a reader looking for a next step finds none, so the piece may move feeling more than action. The benediction trusts that naming the open door is enough to make the reader notice they stopped using it.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage consecrates the public square as the place where citizenship happens. Read it carefully. Then write a well-developed essay in which you analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to elevate the public square and to convey its loss. In your response you should establish a defensible thesis about the writer's rhetorical purpose; select and analyze specific evidence from the passage, attending to choices such as the accumulation of historical examples under a repeated frame, the contrast between belonging and buying, and the closing benediction; explain how those choices work together to create meaning; and demonstrate control of the conventions of written English. Do not summarize the passage.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may label the repeated 'it is to' clauses in paragraph 3 as parallelism when the marked device is anaphora; the test is that the repeated words sit at the START of each clause, which is anaphora, while the marked paragraph-2 device repeats a grammatical shape mid-clause and is parallelism. Press students to locate where the repetition falls.
- Students may read the Stoa paragraph as the writer arguing that modern cities should build covered walkways, mistaking a consecratory detail for a policy proposal. The Tribute register issues no call to action; the walkways honor past care, they do not prescribe future construction.
- Students may treat the personified 'screen took the rest' as literal, claiming the writer says a device physically removed people, rather than reading it as a figure for the migration of civic life to digital platforms.
- Students may assume the opener argues against a named opponent (developers, technology companies) and hunt for a refutation that is not there. The piece consecrates by placement and never rebuts, so an analysis built around a counterargument will misread the stance.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches students to analyze how a consecratory (epideictic) passage builds meaning through accumulation, parallelism, anaphora, antithesis, and a placement-into-permanence close rather than through explicit argument. It exercises Claims and Evidence (characterizing a writer's position) and Style (identifying the primary purpose of a specific detail), and it sharpens the parallelism-versus-anaphora distinction that students routinely blur.